

RIDDHI SEN

RIDDHI SEN, 23

Actor/ director

BURNING BRIGHT

Riddhi became one of the youngest actors to win the National Film Best Actor Award for his portrayal of a eunuch in Kaushik Ganguly's *Nagarkirtan* when he was just 19. Still only 23, he has already worked with a number of notable directors including Aparna Sen, Sujoy Ghosh and Pradeep Sarkar, playing such varied roles as a helper at a tea stall in *Kahaani*, a debauched son in *Parched* and an adorable one who helps his mother find her creative identity in *Helicopter Eela*, and the war-ravaged orphan in *Children of the War*. Many of his films, such as *Parched* or B.R. Mishra's *Chauranga*, were made with international collaboration, and went on to win awards at the Locarno Film Festival. Apart from this, he also directed his first short film in 2020. *Coldfire* won the best short film award at the Miami International Science Fiction film festival. ■

–Romita Datta

THE GASTRONOME Mother Reshmi caters to his fondness for international cuisine by cooking Continental, Mexican and Chinese dishes at home

"A quote I live by is by filmmaker [Alejandro Gonzalez] Inarritu, 'I don't have a career, I have a life'"

The Bigger Cause

PA. RANJITH, 36, *Film director*

Pa. Ranjith's influence on the cinematic and cultural landscape of Tamil Nadu in the past decade has been unlike that of any other film icon. Beginning with his debut film *Attakathi* in 2012 to his latest *Sarpatta Parambarai*, Ranjith has created brilliant films that have also been statements of Dalit assertion in Tamil cinema. His imprint is not just confined to films but is apparent in different spheres of culture through the many organisations he has helped set up, including the Neelam Cultural Centre, Neelam Productions and Neelam Publications. His Neelam cultural centres now have branches and educational projects for Dalits across Tamil Nadu. He has also backed several new-wave filmmakers like Mari Selvaraj, Shyam Sunder, Manoj Leonel Jahson and Athiyan Athirai through The Casteless Collective. His next film, *Natchathiram Nagargirathu*, is a romantic drama, and he's also finalising a project with actor Vikram. ■

–Aditya Shrikrishna

SET APART Housing sets of Ranjith's films like *Madras* can be traced back to the realist aesthetics of films like *Chennai 600028* in which he worked as an assistant



YASIR IQBAL

"I had to reflect on what my stories can say. I wanted to show that my culture itself is based on discrimination, violence"
PA. RANJITH *to The Wire*